- **Assurance matters.** When ACME needs to trust not just an identity but the source and integrity of specific attributes, VCs can provide strong assurance through both technical methods and governance.
- **Multiple authoritative sources are needed in a single decision.** Some policy decisions require claims from several independent organizations—such as employers, certifiers, regulators, or tenants—making VCs an effective way to combine these attributes at decision time.
- **Directory synchronization becomes brittle.** VCs eliminate the need to constantly mirror external data structures inside ACME.

In contrast, long-term internal employees with consistent access patterns may continue to use ACME's traditional account lifecycle. The aim is not uniformity; it is selecting the appropriate tool for each trust model.

16.9.2 Failure modes and fallback paths

Credential-based access introduces new failure modes that ACME must handle gracefully. Most are expected. Here are some of the most common:

- **The holder cannot present the required credential.** Their wallet is offline, unconfigured, or missing the claims needed for the request.
- **A credential has expired or been revoked, and access is denied.** This is the assurance model working as intended. However, from the user's perspective, it may feel like an error, especially if they believe they still hold the relevant role or relationship. In these cases, ACME's workflow should guide the user toward resolution. For example, it might direct them to renew a certification, request an updated delegation from their organization, or contact the issuer responsible for the attribute that no longer meets policy.
- **The issuer is no longer trusted.** A governance update or revocation of issuer accreditation could suddenly invalidate credentials that were previously considered acceptable.
- **Presentation flows fail.** Network interruptions, unsupported wallet features, or browser restrictions can disrupt an otherwise valid session.

ACME must establish fallback workflows for these and similar situations. As discussed in chapter 12, this generally involves exception-based access